05

THE CHECKLIST NOBODY GAVE YOU

Credit. Taxes. Retirement match. Insurance. Four things every adult is expected to know that nobody actually teaches. By Sunday, all four are handled.

CK ACADEMY

A COLLECTIVE KINDNESS INITIATIVE

BRUTALIST SLAB · BOLD WORDMARK

01 READ THIS FIRST

Match first. Everything else after.

Four things every adult is expected to handle by 30: credit, taxes, retirement, insurance. Most frum couples have been formally taught about zero of them.

This class covers all four. But there's only ONE forced action by Sunday: claim your full 401(k) match. Every dollar of match you don't claim is free money you're handing back. By Sunday night, that gap is closed.

Credit, taxes, and insurance are real and important. They're also next-step work that goes on weeks 2, 3, and 4. The match goes first because it's the highest-leverage move and the easiest to forget.

WHAT THIS CLASS IS NOT

Not deep insurance theory. Not a tax strategy lecture. Not a credit-building masterclass. This is the page that ends with you having claimed every dollar of free 401(k) match available to you.

02 THE MIRROR

The four numbers. Match goes first.

WRITE THE NUMBERS FROM YOUR OWN LIFE

Four answers. The first one alone might be costing you $5K/year. The other three matter, but the match is the gate. Find these in 10 minutes total.

1. % of your paycheck you contribute to 401(k). Then: % match your employer offers (HR portal or last paystub).	____ % / ____ %
2. Current credit score (creditkarma.com or your bank app, free, 60 seconds)	_____
3. If you have 1099 income: % of each payment you set aside for taxes (your honest answer, including 0%)	____ %
4. Term life insurance: yes/no, coverage amount, age you bought (if you have it)	_____

If row 1 shows your contribution is below the match, you are walking past free money every paycheck. That's the action of this class. Everything else (credit, taxes, insurance) is the next priority order, addressed below. Match first.

03 THE ORDER MATTERS

Match. Then the rest.

An employer 401(k) match is the closest thing in financial life to free money. If your employer matches 6%, contributing 6% means a guaranteed 100% return on those dollars. Refusing it is the same as turning down a raise.

Most frum couples in their 20s and early 30s aren't claiming the full match. They contribute 2-3% because the form was confusing or they wanted slightly more take-home. Over 30 years that decision costs hundreds of thousands of dollars.

The full 4-item priority order

1. Claim 401(k) match in full. Free money. Always first.

2. Build a credit history. One card, used like a debit card, paid in full monthly. Score climbs without paying a cent of interest.

3. Tax discipline. W-2: check your withholding (big refunds = you loaned the IRS for free). 1099: auto-transfer 30% of every payment to a separate tax account.

4. Term life insurance. 10x annual income. Buy young, buy healthy, buy term not whole. Lock the rate before a diagnosis.

04 THE RULE THAT SIMPLIFIES THE WHOLE LIST

The rule.

AUTOMATE OR IT DIES

If a financial behavior requires you to make a decision every month, you'll quit within 6 months. Every item on this checklist must be set to fire automatically on a calendar schedule, with confirmation arriving by text or email.

What automation looks like for each

401(k): Set contribution to claim full match, plus auto-escalate 1% per year. Now it climbs without willpower.

Credit card: Set to auto-pay full statement balance every month from checking. Never miss a payment. Score climbs.

Tax (1099): Auto-transfer 30% to a separate "tax savings" account the day each payment hits.

Insurance: Auto-pay annual premium so the policy never lapses. Set calendar reminder for 5 years out to re-shop rates.

05 WHERE THIS FAILS

The form is where you'll quit.

Knowing the checklist is easy. Filling out the actual paperwork is where 70% of people stop. Here are the specific moments and how to push through.

TRAP 1 / 401(K) HR FORM LOOKS SCARY

11 fields, 6 fund options, language you don't know. **Pick the target-date fund nearest your retirement year (2055, 2060, 2065).** Set contribution to whatever claims full match. Done in 8 minutes. Don't get fancy.

TRAP 2 / THE WHOLE-LIFE PITCH

An insurance "agent" friend will pitch whole life with a college fund / retirement / death benefit pitch. **The commission on whole life is 50-110% of first-year premium.** That's why he's pitching. Get a term quote from policygenius.com or LADDER yourself. 10x income, 20-30 year term. Ignore the pitch.

TRAP 3 / BIG REFUND = YOU'RE WINNING

A $4,000 refund feels like a win. It's actually you having loaned the IRS $333/month at 0% interest. **Adjust your W-4 to break even or owe a small amount.** Take that $333/month and invest it instead.

TRAP 4 / SIDE HUSTLE INCOME, NO TAX DISCIPLINE

1099 income hits your account. You see the full amount. You spend it. April arrives, you owe $8K, you have $400. **The fix is automatic transfer of 30% to a tax savings account the day each payment lands.** Treat it as never yours.

06 THE ACTION

BY SUNDAY, 9 PM

Do this. Now.

ONE forced action. Claim the full 401(k) match. The other three items (credit, taxes, insurance) become next-steps in week 2-4, after the gate clears.

01 **Log into your employer benefits portal.** Find your current 401(k) contribution rate and the match offered.

If you don't know how to log in, ask HR or your manager. "I'm reviewing my benefits" is the only context needed.

02 **Increase your contribution to claim the FULL match.** If match is 6%, contribute at least 6%. Pick the target-date fund nearest your retirement year (2055, 2060, 2065). Save.

Self-employed? Open a Solo 401(k) or SEP-IRA at Fidelity instead. Same deadline. Different vehicle, same principle.

03 **Screenshot the confirmation page** showing the new contribution rate and the fund selected.

If your portal shows the change as "pending" until next pay period, that counts. Screenshot the pending state.

04 **Text your spouse the screenshot.** Words: "Class 05 done. Match claimed at X%. Free money on autopilot."

If you don't have an employer 401(k), text the SEP-IRA or Solo 401(k) confirmation instead.

PROOF OF COMPLETION

Screenshot showing 401(k) contribution at full match level (or SEP-IRA/Solo 401(k) opened if self-employed), with fund selected. Sent to spouse with "Class 05 done." The credit, tax, and insurance items are next-steps, not gates. Schedule them for the next 3 weeks: credit week 2, tax week 3, insurance week 4.

07 THE CONVERSATION

Tonight. With your spouse.

RULES

30 minutes. Phone away. Bring the four answers from the mirror. Most couples have never aligned on these basics together. Tonight you do.

01 What's our combined credit score, and have we ever pulled it together? If not, why not?

Surprising how many couples have never seen each other's score.

02 Are we BOTH claiming our full 401(k) match? If one of us isn't, what's the dollar amount we're walking past every month?

Run the math. Most are surprised.

03 If something happened to either of us tomorrow, what's the financial picture for the family? Specifically.

Not philosophy. Numbers. Insurance, savings, debt.

04 Whose name is on what? Bank accounts, credit cards, insurance beneficiaries. Are they current?

Most couples have at least one account or beneficiary that hasn't been updated since before marriage.

05 What's the ONE item from this class we'll absolutely close by Sunday, and who owns it?

Pick one. Sign the contract.

SECTION TWO

Test.

10 questions. None of these can be answered from memory of the lesson. You'll need real numbers from your own life.

08 THE TEST

Test.

Each question requires real numbers, real names, or real decisions from your life. Do the work. Skipping defeats the point.

1. NUMBERS **Pull your credit score. Pull your spouse's. Average them. If under 700, list 3 specific factors lowering it (utilization, late payments, no history, etc.) and what you'll change this month.**

2. ACTION **Log into your employer's benefits portal. Screenshot the current 401(k) contribution rate and the offered match rate. Calculate the dollar amount you're walking past per month if you're below the match. Show the math.**

3. DECISION **If you got a tax refund over $1,500 last year, that's a withholding problem. Adjust your W-4 to break even. Calculate the monthly amount that gets freed up, and what it grows to invested at 9% over 30 years.**

4. NUMBERS **Get a term life insurance quote for 10x your annual income, 20-year term. Write the monthly premium. Compare to a whole life policy quote for the same coverage. Show both numbers and the 20-year cost difference.**

5. TRAP TEST **Your insurance agent friend pitches a whole life policy as "college fund + retirement + death benefit, only $480/month." What do you say? Specific response, including what you ask him.**

08 THE TEST, CONTINUED

6. ACTION Open the IRS tax withholding calculator (irs.gov). Enter your numbers. Write what change to your W-4 it recommends. If self-employed, write the 30% transfer rule you're setting up at your bank.

7. REAL LIFE Find one frum person in your community who claims full 401(k) match and one who doesn't. (Don't name them. Just describe the situations.) What's the difference in their thinking?

8. DECISION Whose name is on what in your marriage: bank accounts, credit cards, insurance beneficiaries, retirement accounts? List 3 things you discovered need updating.

9. TRAP TEST Your 401(k) HR form has 6 fund options including "S&P 500 Index," "Fidelity Magellan Fund," "Target Date 2060," "Vanguard Total Bond," "Stable Value," and "Company Stock." Which do you pick if you're 30, why, and what would you NOT pick?

10. ACTION Take the screenshots: 401(k) updated, credit card auto-pay set, withholding adjusted, term quote received. Tape, paste, or staple all four to the back of this book. If they're not there, you didn't do it.

09 WHAT A STRONG ANSWER LOOKS LIKE

Reference.

These aren't right answers. They're examples of strong answers, written with real specificity. If yours are vaguer than these, redo them.

1. Strong: "Mine 692, spouse 718, average 705. Lowering mine: high utilization at 60% (paying down to 30% this month), one missed payment 2 years ago (will fall off in 5 years)." Weak: "I think it's around 700." Pull it. It takes 90 seconds.

2. Strong: "Currently at 3%. Match is 6%. I'm walking past 3% of $80K = $200/month, $2,400/year. Updating to 6% today." Weak: "I'm not sure what the match is." Find out today, not next month.

3. Strong: "Refund $4,200 = $350/month overpayment. Updating W-4 to break even. $350/month at 9% over 30 years = $640,000 in future wealth. The IRS got 0%; I'm taking the money back."

4. Strong: "Term: $48/month for $1M, 20-year term, healthy 30-year-old. Whole life: $640/month for same coverage. Difference over 20 years: $142,000 less in premiums. I'd invest the difference." Whole life salesman will fight this; the math doesn't.

5. Strong: "Show me a quote for term coverage at the same death benefit. Then show me your commission structure on whole life vs term. I want to compare. I'm not signing anything tonight." If he can't show or won't compare, the answer is no.

6. Strong: "Calculator says I should claim 1 fewer dependent on W-4. Will reduce refund from ~$3,200 to ~$200, freeing $250/month. Self-employed spouse: setting up rule at Chase to auto-move 30% of any incoming payment to a labeled tax savings account."

7. Strong: "Person A claims full match because their HR did the paperwork during onboarding. Person B contributes 0 because the forms felt overwhelming and they wanted maximum take-home. Difference in mindset: A treats retirement as part of comp; B treats it as optional."

8. Strong: "Discovered: my Roth IRA still has my parents as beneficiary. Old joint account from school still has my dad on it. Insurance policy from work hasn't been updated since I got married. Updating all 3 this week." Weak: "Probably need to update some things."

9. Strong: "Pick Target Date 2060. It auto-adjusts the stock/bond mix as I age, low fees, hands-off. Would NOT pick: Magellan Fund (active, high fees, lags index), Stable Value (too conservative for 30-year-old), Company Stock (concentration risk, plus you already get income from this company)."

10. All four screenshots required. If any are missing, you didn't complete the class. Don't move to Class 06.